

CASE FILE — FORENSIC EVIDENCE REPORT

Investigation into Structure Fire — Vantage Auto Repair | CASE-2026-0409-ARSON

Case Type:	Arson / Suspicious Fire
Date of Incident:	April 9, 2026, fire reported 02:04 AM
Location:	Vantage Auto Repair, 220 Industrial Blvd.
Reporting Party:	Fire Dept. Battalion Chief — R. Delacroix-Anand
Lead Investigator:	Det. F. Osei, Arson Task Force
Fire Origin Investigator:	Insp. G. Marchetti, Fire Marshal's Office
Digital Forensic Examiner:	L. Whitfield, DFIR Unit
Status:	Open — Active Investigation

1. Case Summary

A fire broke out at Vantage Auto Repair overnight, causing significant structural damage before being brought under control. Fire investigators identified two independent points of origin, inconsistent with an accidental single-source fire. The business owner, Alan Petrescu, had recently increased the property's insurance coverage and was reportedly behind on lease payments.

2. Physical / Scene Evidence

Ex. #	Description	Location Recovered	Collected By
PE-01	Fire debris sample, Point of Origin A (office)	Front office area	Insp. G. Marchetti
PE-02	Fire debris sample, Point of Origin B (bay 3)	Rear service bay 3	Insp. G. Marchetti
PE-03	Partially melted plastic container	Rear service bay 3	Insp. G. Marchetti
PE-04	Point-of-origin pour pattern (photographed & sampled)	Office floor	Insp. G. Marchetti
PE-05	Damaged rear door lock, pried	Rear exterior door	CSI Y. Aldana

3. Digital Evidence

Ex. #	Device / Source	Details	Hash (SHA-256, truncated)
DE-01	Owner's smartphone	Location history, insurance app activity	4c88de...f012
DE-02	Exterior CCTV (offsite neighboring business)	Partial view of rear lot, 01:00–02:15 AM	b910af...6633
DE-03	Insurance policy records (subpoenaed)	Coverage increase dated March 2, 2026	N/A (records)
DE-04	Owner's laptop	Search history re: 'fire investigation process', 'insurance payout timeline'	76ad02...19cf
DE-05	Cell-site location data (owner's phone)	Ping near property at 01:12 AM–01:34 AM	N/A (records)

4. Digital Forensic Analysis Notes

- Fire debris samples PE-01 and PE-02 tested positive for medium-petroleum-distillate accelerant residue by the state fire lab, supporting a determination of intentionally set, multiple-origin fire.
- Neighboring business CCTV (DE-02) shows a vehicle matching the owner's description parked briefly near the rear lot at 01:15 AM, departing at 01:31 AM, roughly 30 minutes before the fire was reported.
- Cell-site data (DE-05) corroborates the owner's phone being in the immediate vicinity of the property during that same window, despite an initial statement that he 'had not been near the shop since closing at 6 PM.'
- Browser history recovered from DE-04 shows search queries related to fire investigation timelines and insurance claim processing dated within the two weeks prior to the fire.
- Insurance records (DE-03) confirm a coverage increase of approximately 40% filed five weeks before the incident, alongside records showing the business was three months behind on lease payments.
- Rear door damage (PE-05) is consistent with forced entry from outside, though investigators note this could also have been staged to suggest a third-party intruder.

5. Witness / Suspect Statements

Alan Petrescu (Business Owner) — statement given April 9, 2026:

I closed up around 6 PM like always and went straight home. I have no idea how this happened; someone must have broken in. This is a huge loss for me.

Alan Petrescu (Follow-up interview, after CCTV review) — statement given April 11, 2026:

I want to speak with my attorney before answering any further questions about my whereabouts that night.

Nia Okonjo (Neighboring shop owner, provided CCTV) — statement given April 9, 2026:

Our camera catches part of the back lot behind Vantage since our buildings share the alley. Happy to provide whatever footage helps the investigation.

6. Chain of Custody

Date	Ex. #	Action	Custodian
2026-04-09	PE-01–PE-05	Collected during scene examination	Insp. G. Marchetti / CSI Y. Aldana
2026-04-09	PE-01, PE-02	Debris samples sealed in unlined cans, sent to state fire lab	Insp. G. Marchetti
2026-04-10	DE-01, DE-04	Devices seized pursuant to search warrant #2026-SW-0509	L. Whitfield, DFIR
2026-04-10	DE-02	CCTV footage obtained voluntarily from neighboring business	Det. F. Osei
2026-04-11	DE-03, DE-05	Records obtained via subpoena	Det. F. Osei

7. Investigator Conclusion

Laboratory confirmation of accelerant use, combined with the owner's contradicted alibi, financial motive, and pre-fire research activity, establishes probable cause for arson and insurance fraud charges against Alan Petrescu. Case has been referred to the District Attorney's office for charging consideration.